is said to have a unique ability to build and maintain relationships and has a reputation for not backing out of any deal he enters into. He does not try to buy out or squeeze his partners. When a deal does not work out as expected, Adani insists on sitting down with the partner and ironing out the rough edges to see it through. Investors love him for his steadfast way of not raising money from them till a business starts to generate cash. This method allows him to get higher valuations at the time of fundraising. Those close to him cite the example of Adani Wilmar. The 50:50 joint venture, stitched in January 1999, remains an equal partnership, with Adani showing no desire to increase his stake in the company. But Adani does believe in size, scale and speed and wants to dominate any industry he gets into.

Moreover, despite the popular notion of him being close to Prime Minister Narenda Modi, he maintains relationships across party lines, making him acceptable to every government. "He has concluded projects under the Congress government, the BJP government, the National Democratic Alliance, the Left parties in Kerala and even the mercurial Mamata Banerjee of the Trinamool Congress in West Bengal," writes journalist R.N. Bhaskar in the book, *Gautam Adani: Reimagining Business in India and the World*. Interestingly, recent protests by a section of fishermen and Catholic priests against Adani's Vizhinjam port project on the southern tip of Kerala saw sworn enemies, the ruling CPI(M) and the BJP, come together in support of the project. Adani, in turn, says protests do not bother him as they are "an essential part of the democratic process".

Adani says the protests against his projects do not bother him as they are "an essential part of the democratic process"

He also shrugs off allegations that the rise of his business empire has to do with Modi's ascent to power, first as Gujarat CM and, in 2014, as India's prime minister. He emphasises that the three major breaks in his entrepreneurial journey were due to policies under former prime ministers Rajiv Gandhi and Narasimha Rao, and ex-Gujarat CM Keshubhai Patel, apart from policies pushed through by Modi when he became CM in 2001 and PM in 2014. Adani emphatically says, "These allegations are baseless and suffer from a recency bias, seeing our group's success through a short-term lens. My professional success is not because of any individual leader but because of the policy and institutional reforms initiated by several leaders and governments over a long period of more than three decades." Adani brushes aside charges of what a former chief economic advisor to the Union finance minister called "stigmatised capitalism", saying in his businesses he had always pushed for a competitive bidding process to snuff out charges of political patronage.

MANAGING THE EMPIRE

Adani likes to run his companies with a judicious mix of professionals from within the family and outside. Brother Rajesh Adani is group MD, sons Karan Adani and Jeet Adani are CEO of Adani Ports and SEZ, and V-P, group finance, respectively. Nephews Pranav Adani and Sagar Adani are MD, agro, oil & gas and executive director, Adani Green Energy, respectively. Asked how he manages such a giant conglomerate, Adani says, "All our businesses are run by professional, competent CEOs. I do not interfere in the day-to-day functioning of the companies. My role is limited to formulating strategy, capital allocation and performance review. It's also why I have the time to not only manage such a large and diverse organisation but also incubate several new businesses and look for new opportunities for acquisitions."

Adani points out proudly that none of the 50-odd assets he has bought in the past seven years, including the distressed ones, have failed precisely because of his "committed team". He believes in pushing his managers to take "entrepreneurial" decisions, with some hand-holding, of course. Executives are encouraged to take big bets, and treat wrong decisions as part of the learning curve. Insiders say he gives operational freedom to the CEOs and keeps his focus on broader strategies and capital allocation. Adani leans on his gut feeling while making decisions, prefers simple and logical solutions, and loathes jargon. He has been in some life-threatening situations, including being trapped in the Taj Mahal Hotel in Mumbai in 2008 during the terrorist attack. Adani had to hide in the basement till they were eliminated. He says, "I am a positive thinker and do not get worked up in any situation. When things are not in your control, why worry? Destiny decides such things. Even on days that have been traumatic, I sleep peacefully."

Adani believes this is India's century and sees the country becoming a $30 trillion economy by 2050 (it is at $3 trillion now), because the median age of the population will still be 38–younger than for any other country. Apart from having a young and aspirational workforce, India will also have the world's largest middle class population. That vision seems to have given him a clear blueprint for the Adani Group's journey in the years ahead. He isn't too fussed about predictions of a global recession in 2023 either, saying, "I am a born optimist and never lose hope. India will emerge stronger from this." It is his never-waste-a-crisis approach and the extraordinary ability to create enormous value in whatever he does that has propelled Adani to the pinnacle of Indian business in just decades. With a large part of that expansive growth happening in 2022, Gautam Adani is without doubt INDIA TODAY's Newsmaker of the Year. ■